

Title DE Storm-1516 and R-FBI: Russian Attempts to Interfere in the German Election 13/02/2025

Summary

- Between November 5th and February 9th, two influence operations originating from Russia planted and spread 12 German-language narratives in the form of articles or videos which were amplified by 10 influencers.
- The articles and posts discredited political candidates from the German Greens, the CDU and Ukraine.
- The posts gained at least 25 million views and 5610 interactions. Two AfD-affiliated accounts including one MP amplified the campaign.
- The influence operation aimed to defame its targets by using deep-fakes, fabricated news websites, and by baiting influencers to spread the content, interfering in the German elections.
- Recommendation: Raise awareness on how these influence operations work to avoid unintentional amplification.

Incident

Between November 5th and February 9th, the Russian influence operations Storm-1516 ([1](#)) and the Foundation to Battle Injustice published 12 German-language articles or videos (e.g. [2](#), [3](#), [4](#), [5](#)). The articles are fabricating claims, attempting to discredit CDU and Green politicians. These include allegations against the Green's and CDU's top candidates as well as Ursula von der Layen, accusing them of abuse. After the end of the traffic light coalition in November 2024, Storm-1516 activities intensified. The articles and their content were amplified by 10 influencers through text and video on X, TikTok, Telegram, YouTube, Facebook, and Instagram (e.g. [6](#), [7](#), [8](#), [9](#)). The influence operations are likely under the control of the Foundation to Battle Injustice ([10](#)) and aim to interfere in the German Federal elections.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Degradation of anti-Russian party; Ruling party is Degradation of Ukraine; Country's government fails to uphold democratic standards and the rule of law.

Sub-narratives: Politician is a Russian agent; Government is re-enacting military conscription; Government working to stop freedom of Speech; Politician is a pedophile; Government letting in global majority migrants; Muslim immigrants are a threat to the Western society; Governing party is corrupt; Politician is mentally ill; Ruling parties planning false-flag terrorist attacks blamed on opposition; The Ukrainian government is corrupt; Ukrainian Government are Nazis; German government is failing its citizens by supporting Ukraine over domestic issues.

Impact

Reach: X, Telegram and TikTok claim that the posts promoting the content or narratives gained at least 25 million views. Across all the platforms, the 157 posts gained around 9750 interactions. It's possible that the numbers are manipulated considering the discrepancy between the number of likes and views.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

[T0140.001: Defame](#) – The influence operation is trying to discredit political candidates and Ukraine;

[T0079: Divide](#) – The influence operations are trying to feed polarisation within German society;

[T0098.001: Create Inauthentic News Sites](#) – The influence operation Storm-1516 created hundreds of inauthentic news sites to promote and give legitimacy to their content;

[T0087.001: Develop AI-Generated Videos \(Deepfakes\)](#) – The operation is using deepfakes to device audiences;

[T0039: Bait Influencer](#) – The operation seemingly managed to bait AfD politicians to amplify the content.

[T0129.003: Break Association with Content](#) – The influence operation is relying on third-party publications.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Flagged case to EU and German authorities and the social media platforms;

Recommendations: Raise awareness on how these influence operations work to avoid unintentional amplification.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
German English	German Elections, CIB Network.	Upon request	Julia Smirnova, CeMAS, Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe; Karolin Schwarz, Independent.	X, Telegram, TikTok.	Meta,